

Afternoon Discoveries: October 6, 2026

Science Fiction & Fantasy



AMONG THE LETTERS

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Science Fiction & Fantasy

Science fiction and fantasy are especially good at making familiar things strange. A train platform can become a place where the boundaries between people are difficult to maintain, a magic sword can arrive with its own set of instructions, and a city can be built around rules that nobody remembers choosing. Today's discoveries move between myth, technology, altered bodies, impossible objects, and the quieter question of what happens when a speculative idea becomes part of ordinary life. There are stories that approach the fantastic through old forms and others that build entirely new ones from contemporary anxieties. Around them are essays and conversations about how speculative fiction works, how readers decide what counts as literary SFF, and how writers carry older stories into new shapes.

All links in today's edition were checked against the linked publication, magazine, publisher, or literary source page on October 5, 2026.

Featured Discovery

Cutting Corners - Yoon Ha Lee

Yoon Ha Lee's "Cutting Corners" follows a group of pilots being trained to fly spacecraft in a war where human beings have become cheaper than machines. The premise immediately turns an economic calculation into a question about the value assigned to human life, especially when the people making the calculations are safely removed from the battlefield. The story combines military science fiction with a strong interest in the relationships that develop among people who know they have been placed in an expendable position. Its spaceships, simulated

battles, command structures, and desperate maneuvers give the story plenty of traditional science-fiction machinery, but the emotional centre remains the people inside it. Lee gradually turns the idea of “cutting corners” from a practical military decision into something much larger about what societies are willing to sacrifice.

[Read “Cutting Corners” at Reactor](#)

The Discovery Desk

This Is Not My Timeline - J.R. Dawson

J.R. Dawson’s “This Is Not My Timeline” begins with a couple who have reached the point where remaining in their home has become impossible, so they turn to an extraordinary real-estate solution: moving to another timeline. The speculative premise creates a deceptively simple question about what it means to leave a place behind, particularly when the things being left are not just possessions but memories, relationships, routines, and versions of oneself. Dawson makes the alternate timeline feel strange through small details rather than relying only on spectacular changes between universes. The story gradually becomes less about escaping into a better world and more about the difficult work of making a new place into somewhere that can be called home. Its emotional centre is the recognition that migration and displacement cannot be reduced to simply moving from one address to another.

[Read “This Is Not My Timeline” at Reactor](#)

138 Express Inbound - Caleb Astey

Caleb Astey's "138 Express Inbound" begins on a train platform where the ordinary rhythms of transit are interrupted by something passengers would rather not confront. Charles keeps falling asleep on the bench, and the speaker knows that the arrival of the train will bring another set of people whose circumstances cannot be treated as routine. The story gradually gives the platform a strange social geography, where some passengers belong comfortably to the system and others arrive carrying histories that make them difficult to categorize. That distinction turns a familiar commute into something more uneasy, particularly as the narrator becomes increasingly aware of what the system is designed to ignore. Astey uses the machinery of public transportation to ask questions about movement, belonging, and the people who become visible only when a society decides they are a problem.

Read "138 Express Inbound" at [Strange Horizons](#)

The Day-Blind Stars - Christopher Rowe

Christopher Rowe's "The Day-Blind Stars" follows an Earth explorer who ventures outward into space and eventually finds herself travelling through the universe alongside a small god. The story stretches across an enormous span of time, giving its science-fiction setting an unusual sense of scale. Rather than treating space simply as a destination for adventure, Rowe uses the vastness of the universe to explore loneliness, memory, companionship, and the persistence of wonder. The central journey has an almost mythic quality, with the explorer continuing outward while the meaning of the journey changes around her. Its combination of far-future science fiction and something resembling a

small personal mythology makes it particularly well suited to an afternoon devoted to the border between science fiction and fantasy.

[Read "The Day-Blind Stars" at Reactor](#)

The Night of the Grandmothers - Malena Salazar Maciá

Malena Salazar Maciá's "The Night of the Grandmothers" begins with a village preparing for a night that the children are not supposed to understand. Elena watches as her grandmother and the other older women leave their homes carrying lamps, following a ritual whose purpose becomes increasingly unsettling as the night progresses. What initially resembles a mysterious family custom gradually opens into something much stranger, involving the dead, the swamp, and a community that seems to know far more than it is willing to explain. The story uses the perspective of a child to make its supernatural world particularly effective, because Elena understands the emotional consequences long before she understands the rules governing them. It is an atmospheric piece of dark fantasy that turns family tradition into something both protective and terrifying.

[Read "The Night of the Grandmothers" at The Dark Magazine](#)

Thank you for spending some time with this afternoon's edition. Below this point are six more works of science fiction and fantasy, three pieces about writing and reading, and three special recommendations from the back shelf.

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More From the Discovery Desk

Waru Waru - Ruth Joffre

Ruth Joffre's "Waru Waru" explores memory as something that can be passed from one person to another, turning family history into a physical and sometimes overwhelming inheritance. The story begins with Abuelita feeding memories to the narrator, who receives not just pleasant recollections but the painful details of another life. That structure lets Joffre explore the complicated relationship between remembering someone and carrying what they remember for them. Family, landscape, illness, loss, and cultural memory become intertwined as the story moves between generations. The speculative mechanism is unusual enough to make familiar experiences feel newly tangible, while the emotional questions remain recognizably human.

[Read "Waru Waru" at Lightspeed Magazine](#)

Mothsblood - Lynn D. Jung

Lynn D. Jung's *Mothsblood* begins with an ambitious alchemist whose university becomes the centre of an impossible murder. The headmistress is immortal, which makes her death less a straightforward mystery than an event that immediately destabilizes the assumptions everyone around her has been relying upon. Larkspur Lee is already

carrying a complicated history with the cult suspected of the crime, so solving the murder means navigating a danger she would rather leave behind. The university setting gives the fantasy an appealing tension between intellectual ambition and the much darker secrets that institutions can conceal. Jung's excerpt suggests a story where academic rivalry, alchemy, murder, and buried history are all pulling on the same thread.

[Read an excerpt from "Mothsblood" at Reactor](#)

The Scarlet Ball - Nghi Vo

Nghi Vo's *The Scarlet Ball* takes the polished social world of New York's Four Hundred and gives it a supernatural appetite. Judith Ban is a former convent girl, courtesan, and failed thief who agrees to assume another woman's identity, only to discover that the world she is entering is governed by rituals far more dangerous than etiquette. The transformation is literal as well as social, with Judith given a new face and expected to perform a role that can cost her much more than reputation. Vo uses the rituals of wealth, marriage, and social power as the surface of a darker fantasy in which the women controlling the room may be negotiating with demons as well as with one another. The result promises a story where ambition is not simply a route upward but a way of surviving a world that has already decided what a woman is allowed to become.

[Read an excerpt from "The Scarlet Ball" at Reactor](#)

Under the Iron Sky - A. T. Emerald

A. T. Emerald's *Under the Iron Sky* opens a dark fantasy trilogy in the world of Vordell, where a fallen empire has left behind a landscape in

which power and survival remain tightly connected. At its centre is a warrior trying to protect her people and a masked soldier who captures her behind enemy lines. The premise puts political conflict and personal danger into immediate proximity, but the accompanying material also emphasizes the physical construction of the world itself. Maps, endpapers, and other visual details become part of the invitation, giving the setting a sense of something designed to be explored rather than merely described. It is an appealing choice for readers who enjoy fantasy that treats its invented geography as an active part of the story's emotional machinery.

[Discover *Under the Iron Sky* at Reactor](#)

The Redemption Center Is Closed on Sundays - Andrea Hairston

Andrea Hairston's *The Redemption Center Is Closed on Sundays* is described by Reactor as a novel of enormous abundance, one that gathers many lives into a single expansive fictional structure. Rather than reducing its characters to pieces moving toward one central plot, the book seems interested in the details of the people whose lives touch one another, even briefly. That approach makes the novel feel particularly suited to readers who enjoy speculative fiction that allows a world to become complicated through accumulation rather than explanation. Humor, affection, history, and the ordinary textures of individual lives all have room to coexist inside its larger design. The attraction is not simply the scale of the book but the sense that its abundance is being used to make room for people who might otherwise disappear at the edges of a more tightly controlled story.

[Read the review of *The Redemption Center Is Closed on Sundays* at Reactor](#)

Palaces of the Crow - Ray Nayler

Ray Nayler's *Palaces of the Crow* is the subject of a new review in the October 5 issue of *Strange Horizons*. Nayler's speculative fiction frequently explores unfamiliar forms of intelligence, the boundaries between human and nonhuman perspectives, and the consequences of encountering systems that do not share our assumptions. Even the title suggests a world in which intelligence and environment have been rearranged, with the ordinary becoming strange through a shift in perspective. The review by Alex Kingsley offers an opportunity to approach the work through contemporary speculative criticism rather than simply through its premise, making it useful for readers interested in how current science fiction is being interpreted as well as written. It is a particularly timely discovery for October 6 because it comes from the current issue of one of the field's long-running literary SFF magazines.

[Read the review of *Palaces of the Crow* at Strange Horizons](#)

Beyond the First Shelf

Infinite Wishes - Kristine Kathryn Rusch

Kristine Kathryn Rusch's "Infinite Wishes" begins with Rachel sitting beside a secluded pond after spending years searching for a particular place. The opening immediately gives the fantasy a sense of patience, suggesting that whatever Rachel has come looking for is connected to a long-held desire rather than a simple adventure. The small lights rising from the water create an atmosphere that is beautiful before it becomes fully understandable, allowing the story to build its magic

through suggestion. The idea of wishes carries its own familiar set of expectations, but fantasy becomes interesting when the consequences of getting what someone wants prove more complicated than the wish itself. Rusch uses that tension to create a story that feels rooted in traditional fairy-tale territory while still approaching the idea of desire from a contemporary perspective.

[Read "Infinite Wishes" at Lightspeed Magazine](#)

Two Sides of a Scratched Coin - Martin Cahill with Micaiah Johnson

Martin Cahill's conversation with Micaiah Johnson looks at the complicated relationship between speculative fiction and horror. Johnson's work has already moved between science fiction, alternate realities, and increasingly unsettling territory, and the conversation considers how those genres can create different pressures around character and fear. The interview also offers a glimpse into the thinking behind *The Unhaunting*, a novel that follows a writer whose earlier work established a reputation for ambitious speculative world-building. What makes the conversation useful is its attention to craft rather than treating genre as a set of fixed boxes. For writers and readers alike, it is a reminder that the boundary between speculative fiction and horror is often more porous than the shelves suggest.

[Read "Two Sides of a Scratched Coin" at Reactor](#)

The Punishing Animal - B. Pladek

B. Pladek's "The Punishing Animal" places a young narrator inside a tightly controlled ecological refuge where even ordinary encounters with nature carry the weight of a much larger social system. The story

begins with birds, a boy, and an environment that looks protected on the surface but is governed by restrictions about where people may go and what lives they are permitted to lead. The ecological setting gradually becomes inseparable from questions about family, authority, class, and the meaning of being protected by a society that does not necessarily value your freedom. Pladek uses the speculative future to make familiar ideas about environmental preservation feel unsettlingly complicated. The result is a story that combines climate fiction with a coming-of-age perspective and a darker examination of who gets to decide what should be preserved.

Read “The Punishing Animal” at [Lightspeed Magazine](#)

Special Recommendations

The Machine Stops - E. M. Forster

E. M. Forster’s “The Machine Stops” remains one of the great speculative stories about a society that has made convenience indistinguishable from necessity. People live underground in isolated rooms, communicating through a vast technological system that provides nearly everything they need without requiring them to encounter the physical world directly. The story is old enough to feel historical and familiar enough to feel uncomfortably contemporary. Forster is less interested in predicting a particular technology than in examining what happens when a system becomes so complete that people can no longer imagine life outside it. Read it now and the strange thing is not

how futuristic it feels, but how many of its questions have become ordinary.

[Read "The Machine Stops" free through Project Gutenberg](#)

The Time Machine - H. G. Wells

H. G. Wells's *The Time Machine* is often remembered as the story that helped establish time travel as a science fiction idea, but its deeper fascination lies in what the traveller finds when he reaches the distant future. Humanity has divided into two very different forms, and the apparent simplicity of the world above ground hides a much darker relationship between them. Wells uses the fantastic premise to look at class, inequality, progress, and the possibility that civilization can change without becoming wiser. The machine itself is almost less important than the perspective it gives its traveller, because moving through time becomes a way of making the present look strange. It remains an excellent reminder that science fiction can use an impossible invention to ask very old questions about the society we have already built.

[Read *The Time Machine* free through Project Gutenberg](#)

The Wonderful Wizard of Oz - L. Frank Baum

L. Frank Baum's *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz* is sometimes treated as familiar children's fantasy, but its imaginative construction still has a great deal of life in it. Dorothy is swept away from Kansas into a world where witches, talking animals, enchanted objects, and dangerous landscapes are ordinary parts of the journey. The story understands

that fantasy works best when the strange world is allowed to have its own logic rather than constantly being explained back to the reader. Its companions are also built around desires that are immediately legible, giving the adventure a simple emotional structure beneath all the colour and spectacle. Returning to Oz is a useful reminder that a story can be wonderfully strange without needing to be obscure.

Read *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz* free through Project Gutenberg

Thank you for spending part of your day among the letters with us. Today's shelf keeps returning to the idea that the speculative begins when something familiar stops behaving in the way we expect. A train platform becomes a border, a sword becomes a set of instructions, a fairy-tale object becomes a tool for examining the self, and a machine becomes an entire civilization's idea of reality. The best science fiction and fantasy does not simply take us somewhere else, because it also changes the way the place we already inhabit looks when we return to it.

Take care!

✓ **Subscribed**